Creating and Editing Raster Images

Part of creating great motion graphic projects is having a solid understanding of creating and editing still images and illustrations.

Professional motion graphic artists use many different programs such as Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator, Adobe XD, GIMP and others to create these graphics and illustrations. In this lab we will learn how to create and edit raster images using Adobe Photoshop.

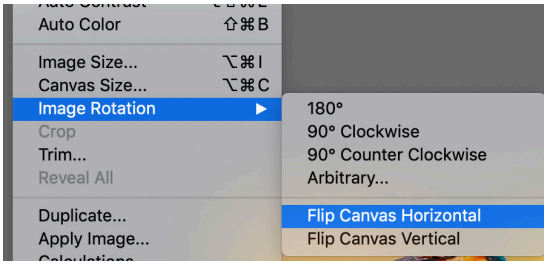
Adobe Photoshop

Adobe Photoshop is the industry standard when it comes to image editing and raster graphics. Raster graphics are graphics that are built using pixels arranged in rows and columns. Adobe Photoshop is currently available for both the Windows and Mac OSX operating system.

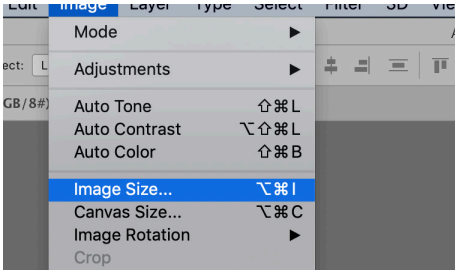
This lab is not meant to cover the entire Adobe Photoshop program, but instead just some of the basic features. I recommend students consider taking *DIGM6A - Adobe Photoshop* to gain a more in-depth knowledge of the tool.

Edit a Photo

We are going to begin by loading an image into Photoshop and editing it. Begin by loading the Adobe Photoshop application on your computer. After loading the progam go to the *File* menu at the top left and choose *Open*. From the dialogue box load *Bird.psd* from the lab files.

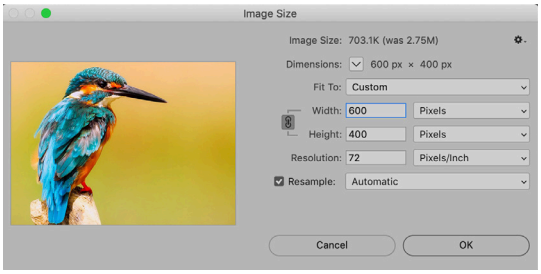


Let's begin by flipping the image so that the bird faces to the right, instead of the left. To do this go to *Image > Image Rotation > Flip Canvas Horizontally.* The result will be youl see the image flip.



Next, let's look at the dimensions of our image. To do this we are going to go to *Image > Image Size* in the menu. This option will open a dialogue box that shows the dimensions of the file. If not already, make sure the dimensions are measured in pixels.

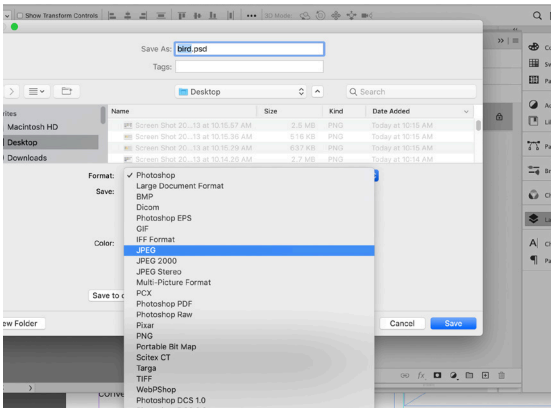
Good design practices would state it is best **not** to make raster images larger than the default size. Increasing a raster image's dimension would cause image distortion. That being said, we can make the image smaller without any issues of quality distortion. Let's change the dimensions from *1200px x 800px* to *600px x 400px*. To do this click in the *width* and *height* boxes to type in the new values. To save the changes click the *OK* button at the bottom right of the dialogue box.



Save the changes you've done to the file by going to *File > Save*.

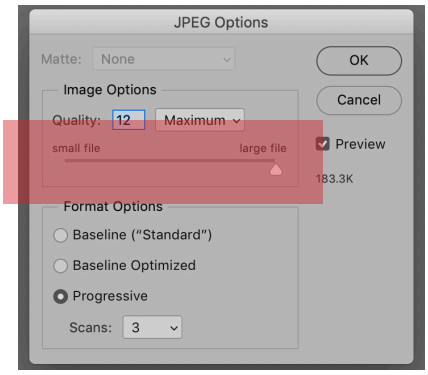
© David Hurwich

Export to Alternative File Formats



The default file format of Adobe Photoshop is the *.psd* or *Photoshop Document*. It is typically recommended to use the *.psd* format to save complex documents with Adobe Photoshop. That being said, there may be times where we may not be able to use the PSD format in a project. Not all graphic dsign applications accept the .PSD image format so we may need to convert it to alternative raster image format.

Go to *File > Save As*. This will open a new dialogue box that allows you to save the image as an alternative image format. Name the file *lastname-bird* and save the image to your *Desktop*. Under *Format*, make sure the image format is set to JPG and hit *Save*. This will convert the document to a *JPEG* file format.



In the *JPEG Option*s dialogue box make sure *Quality* is set to 12 for maximum image quality, Hit *OK* and your file will be converted to a *JPG* format

Crop an Image



Now that have the basics on Photoshop down, let's learn how to crop an image. Many times we may want to crop an unnecessary or bad part from our main image.

Open *crop.psd* into Photoshop. When you open the image you'll see a beautiful desert landscape, but also part of a hiker on the right hand side. This is a bit distracting, so let's crop the hiker from our image using the *crop tool.*



Choose the *crop tool* from the toolbox on the left hand side of the program to enter crop mode. The *crop tool* looks like two L's overlapping one another. Use the white edges of the rectangle to set the prime area. The area that outside of the prime area will be grayed out, this will be the area that will be cropped. When you are done setting your prime area hit the *Enter / Return* key on your keyboard or use the √ in the tool option bar at the top right to finalize the crop.

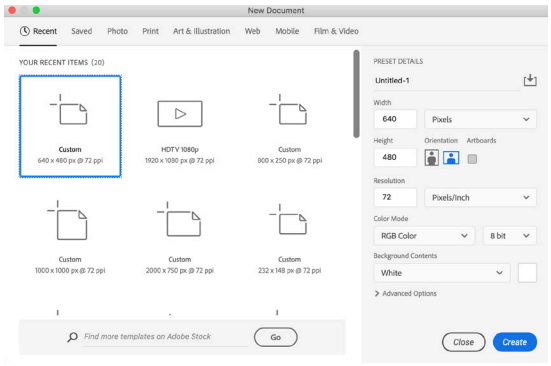


If you are unhappy with the crop go to *Edit > Undo* to undo your last action in the program and repeat the crop action again.

Save *Crop.psd* as JPG to your computer and label it *lastname-crop.jpg*. Store it for your submission.

© David Hurwich

Create a New Document



So Photoshop can open and make basic changes to an existing image, but what if we want to make our own more sophisticated document? To do this we will create a document from scratch.

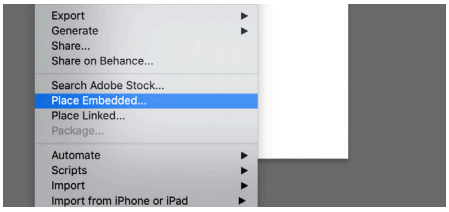
Go to *File > New* to create a new document from scratch in Photoshop. When you create a new document in Adobe Photoshop you will be asked to set the properties of the document.

The first property is the *dimensions* or size of the document. For motion graphics we typically use pixels as our measurement system. Set your document to *640px x 480px*.

The next two options are *Resolution* and *Color Mode*. These properties come into play when you are deciding on whether the image will be used for print projects like a poster or business car, versus a screen project like a video or website image. In this class all of our projects are screen based projects. The proper *resolution* for a screen project is 72 pixels / inch and the proper *Color Mode* is *RGB* with a 8-bit depth.

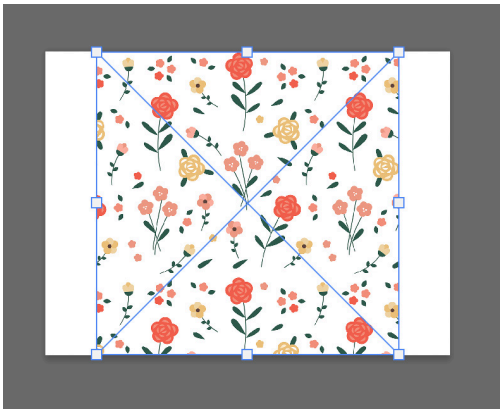
Hit *Ok* to create your new document.

Add Image



Now that we have a canvas, let's begin by adding images into our document.

Go to *File > Place and Embed* and load *floral.jpg*. You will see that a floral design has now been added to our canvas. You can use the built-in *free transform* options to resize and place the floral design within the canvas. Hit *return* or use the √ in the menu toolbar at the top right to finalize the resizing.

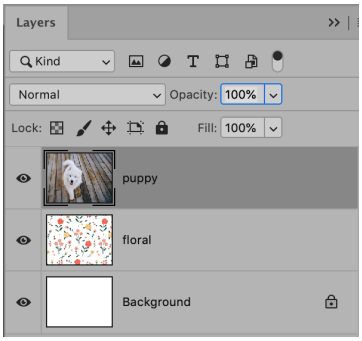


Now that we have added one image, let's add a second. Go to *File > Open and Place* and load *puppy.jpg* into your file. Resize and place the puppy image within the canvas as you did with the floral design.

Feel free to add additional images to your document if you want to.

© David Hurwich

Layers / Transparency



Part of creating a complicated visual composition with Adobe Photoshop is using something called *Layers*. When you place and embed images into Photoshop you are automatically creating a *layer*. Think of layers like pieces of paper that are stacked one on top of one another. To view your document layers use the *Layers* panel at the lower right hand side of the application. If the *Layers* panel has been closed you can reopen it by going to *Windows > Layers*.



In the composition on the right the puppy layer is stacked on top of the floral design layer. To create a blend between the two layers use the *Opacity* option in the *Layers* panel. *Opacity* is the measurement of how opaque or visible a layer is. To make our puppy layer semi-transparent set the opacity from *100%* to *50%*. If you have multiple layers feel free to affect the opacity for each layer.

Add Text



Finally, let's add some text to our document. Begin by clicking on *T-icon* in the toolbox on the left hand side of the application, this is our *Text Tool*.

Click on the composition to add text. Once text has been added use the keyboard to set the text to your name. This will automatically create a layer within the layer stack.



Once you have typed your name, use the *Text tool* to highlight it. You can then use the text options in the tool options bar at the top of the document to change / modify the text. Use the toolbar to change the typeface and the size of the text to make it larger or smaller.

Save your file as *Lastname-Photoshop.psd*. It is important to keep it as *.psd* file in order to maintain your separate layers in the project.

Download & Submit

Great work!

Place *yourname-bird.jpg*, *yourname-crop.jpg* and *yourname-banner.psd* into a folder with your name on it. Zip the folder and submit it to appropriate place on Canvas.

© David Hurwich